LARKSPUR & CO.

THE FIRST THREE DAYS, WEEKS AND MONTHS

The Rescue Dog Settling-In Guide

A calm, step-by-step guide and journal for your rescue dog's first three months, built around the 3-3-3 guide many rescues use.

28 pages | Print at home | Kind, reward-based



Every rescue dog settles at their own pace. Go slowly.

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START HERE

Welcome home

Adopting a rescue dog is a wonderful thing to do. It can also be a lot. Your new dog doesn't know you, your home or your routine yet, and they may have been through a great deal before they reached you.

This guide helps you through the first few months, one stage at a time. It's built around the "3-3-3" guide that many rescues share: **three days** to decompress, **three weeks** to learn your routine, and **three months** to start feeling truly at home.

INSIDE

- [ ] The 3-3-3 guide explained
- [ ] Getting ready checklists
- [ ] A calm first day and a decompression plan
- [ ] Daily logs for the first three days
- [ ] Weekly pages for the first three weeks
- [ ] Monthly check-ins for the first three months
- [ ] Body language guide and trigger log
- [ ] Bonding activities, records and a care sheet

THE MOST IMPORTANT THING

Go slowly. Every dog settles at their own pace. Some relax within days, others need many months. That's normal, and it isn't a sign you're doing anything wrong.

This guide is general information and isn't a substitute for advice from your vet, your rescue or a qualified behaviourist.

NOTES

INSIDE

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UNDERSTANDING IT

The 3-3-3 guide

A rough guide, not a rule. Think of it as a reminder to be patient, especially at the start.

3 DAYS

Decompress

Your dog may feel overwhelmed, scared or shut down. They might not eat much, may hide, or may seem very quiet, or very unsettled. Keep life calm, quiet and predictable. Don't expect much.

3 WEEKS

Learn the routine

Your dog starts working out the routine: when meals happen, where they sleep, when walks are. Their true personality starts to show, and some new behaviours may appear as they get more confident.

3 MONTHS

Feel at home

Many dogs begin to feel settled and trust you. Your bond grows and the routine feels normal. Some dogs take longer, and that's okay.

WHAT I'M EXPECTING (AND WORRIED ABOUT)

GETTING READY

Before your dog arrives

Get everything ready so the first day can be calm.

SHOPPING

- [ ] A comfy bed (or two)
- [ ] Food your rescue used, to start with
- [ ] Bowls
- [ ] Collar and ID tag with your name and address
- [ ] Well-fitting harness and lead
- [ ] Poo bags
- [ ] A few toys and long-lasting chews
- [ ] Lick mat or puzzle feeder

HOME

- [ ] A quiet "safe space" set up
- [ ] Baby gates if needed
- [ ] Fences and gates checked
- [ ] Bins and food out of reach
- [ ] Cables tidied away

ADMIN

- [ ] Register with a vet
- [ ] Microchip transferred into your name
- [ ] Insurance arranged
- [ ] Rescue paperwork filed in this guide

PEOPLE

- [ ] Household agrees the house rules
- [ ] Visitors on hold for a week or two
- [ ] Someone at home for the first days
- [ ] Plan for any other pets

NOTES

GETTING READY

A safe space

A quiet spot where your dog can retreat and be left alone. It's one of the most helpful things you can give them.

SETTING IT UP

- [ ] Somewhere quiet, away from the front door and busy areas
- [ ] A comfy bed, maybe covered to feel like a den
- [ ] Water nearby
- [ ] Something that smells of you
- [ ] Calm music or white noise if they like it

HOUSE RULES FOR EVERYONE

- [ ] When the dog is in their safe space, leave them be
- [ ] Let the dog come to you, rather than reaching for them
- [ ] No hugging or leaning over them at first
- [ ] Keep voices low and movements calm
- [ ] Children supervised at all times

OUR SAFE SPACE PLAN

Where _____ Bed / crate _____

NOTES

OUR HOUSE RULES

THE FIRST DAY

Bringing your dog home

Plan for a quiet, boring day. Boring is good!

1 **The journey**
Bring water, a towel and poo bags. Use a secure harness or crate in the car.

2 **Arriving**
Walk calmly round the garden or outside area first, on lead, so they can sniff and go to the toilet.

3 **Inside**
Let them explore on lead or with gates, one or two rooms at a time. Show them water and their safe space.

4 **Leave them be**
Sit quietly nearby. Let them approach you. Don't worry if they don't want a fuss.

5 **Food**
Offer a small meal. Many dogs don't eat much on day one, and that's normal.

6 **Night**
A last toilet trip, then a calm bedtime. Some dogs settle better with you nearby at first.

HOW THE FIRST DAY WENT

UNDERSTANDING YOUR DOG

Reading body language

Dogs tell us a lot without barking. Learning the signs helps you know when your dog is happy, and when they need space.

RELAXED

- [ ] Soft, loose body
- [ ] Mouth relaxed or slightly open
- [ ] Soft eyes, normal blinking
- [ ] Tail at a natural height, loose wag
- [ ] Sleeping deeply, belly up

WORRIED

- [ ] Lip licking and yawning (when not tired)
- [ ] Turning head away
- [ ] Whites of the eyes showing
- [ ] Ears pinned back
- [ ] Tail tucked low
- [ ] Pacing, panting, shaking off

NEEDS SPACE NOW

- [ ] Freezing or going stiff
- [ ] Staring hard
- [ ] Lip curling
- [ ] Growling
- [ ] Raised hackles
- [ ] Snapping

Growling is communication
A growl is your dog saying "I'm uncomfortable". Never punish it. Calmly give your dog more space, notice what caused it, and avoid that situation while you get help if needed.

SIGNS I'VE NOTICED IN MY DOG

DAY
1

THE FIRST THREE DAYS · DECOMPRESS

Just arrive

Date _____

Today is just about arriving. No visitors, no big walks, no training. Let your dog sleep, sniff and watch.

EATING & DRINKING

TIME	WHAT / HOW MUCH	ATE?

TOILET

TIME	WEE / POO	WHERE

SLEEP & REST

WALKS & OUTSIDE TIME

SIGNS OF STRESS I NOTICED

SIGNS OF RELAXING I NOTICED

Dog's stress level ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

My stress level ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

NOTES

DAY
2

THE FIRST THREE DAYS · DECOMPRESS

Quiet and calm

Date _____

Keep the routine simple: meals, toilet trips, short calm walks or garden time, and lots of rest. Notice what helps your dog relax.

EATING & DRINKING

TIME	WHAT / HOW MUCH	ATE?

TOILET

TIME	WEE / POO	WHERE

SLEEP & REST

WALKS & OUTSIDE TIME

SIGNS OF STRESS I NOTICED

SIGNS OF RELAXING I NOTICED

Dog's stress level ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

My stress level ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

NOTES

DAY
3

THE FIRST THREE DAYS · DECOMPRESS

Small steps

Date _____

Start building gentle routines. A short sniffy walk somewhere quiet, a lick mat, and time to rest. Still no pressure.

EATING & DRINKING

TIME	WHAT / HOW MUCH	ATE?

TOILET

TIME	WEE / POO	WHERE

SLEEP & REST

WALKS & OUTSIDE TIME

SIGNS OF STRESS I NOTICED

SIGNS OF RELAXING I NOTICED

Dog's stress level ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

My stress level ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

NOTES

STAGE TWO

The first three weeks

Your dog is learning your routine. Keep life predictable, start gentle training games, and build trust through calm, positive time together.

NOTES

THE FIRST THREE WEEKS

Week 1

Week starting _____

Focus on routine: meals, walks, toilet trips and bedtime at roughly the same times each day. Start short alone-time practice.

OUR ROUTINE THIS WEEK

	MORNING	MIDDAY	AFTERNOON	EVENING
Meals				
Walks				
Toilet trips				
Training / play				
Rest				

NEW THINGS WE TRIED

WHAT MY DOG LOVED

WHAT WORRIED MY DOG

ALONE-TIME PRACTICE

DAY	HOW LONG	HOW IT WENT

WINS THIS WEEK

THE FIRST THREE WEEKS

Week 2

Week starting _____

Add one or two gentle training games, like the name game or "sit" for a treat. Try a new quiet walking route.

OUR ROUTINE THIS WEEK

	MORNING	MIDDAY	AFTERNOON	EVENING
Meals				
Walks				
Toilet trips				
Training / play				
Rest				

NEW THINGS WE TRIED

WHAT MY DOG LOVED

WHAT WORRIED MY DOG

ALONE-TIME PRACTICE

DAY	HOW LONG	HOW IT WENT

WINS THIS WEEK

THE FIRST THREE WEEKS

Week 3

Week starting _____

Notice how far you've come. Plan any next steps: a vet check, a training class, or a behaviourist if you need one.

OUR ROUTINE THIS WEEK

	MORNING	MIDDAY	AFTERNOON	EVENING
Meals				
Walks				
Toilet trips				
Training / play				
Rest				

NEW THINGS WE TRIED

WHAT MY DOG LOVED

WHAT WORRIED MY DOG

ALONE-TIME PRACTICE

DAY	HOW LONG	HOW IT WENT

WINS THIS WEEK

STAGE THREE

The first three months

Many dogs start to feel truly at home now. Keep building trust, keep life predictable, and celebrate how far you've both come.

NOTES

THE FIRST THREE MONTHS

Month 1 check-in

Date _____

CONFIDENCE

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

RELAXING AT HOME

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

OUT ON WALKS

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

HOW MY DOG HAS CHANGED

STILL FINDING HARD

TRAINING PROGRESS

HEALTH & VET NOTES

NEXT MONTH, WE'LL WORK ON

THE FIRST THREE MONTHS

Month 2 check-in

Date _____

CONFIDENCE

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

RELAXING AT HOME

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

OUT ON WALKS

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

HOW MY DOG HAS CHANGED

STILL FINDING HARD

TRAINING PROGRESS

HEALTH & VET NOTES

NEXT MONTH, WE'LL WORK ON

THE FIRST THREE MONTHS

Month 3 check-in

Date _____

CONFIDENCE

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

RELAXING AT HOME

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

OUT ON WALKS

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

HOW MY DOG HAS CHANGED

STILL FINDING HARD

TRAINING PROGRESS

HEALTH & VET NOTES

NEXT MONTH, WE'LL WORK ON

BUILDING TRUST

Bonding activities

Low-pressure ways to build trust and help your dog relax. Tick the ones your dog enjoys.

CALM & SNIFFY

- [ ] Slow "sniffari" walks somewhere quiet
- [ ] Scatter feeding in the garden
- [ ] Lick mats and stuffed food toys
- [ ] Snuffle mat
- [ ] Sitting together quietly

GENTLE GAMES

- [ ] The name game
- [ ] Find the treat (hide and seek)
- [ ] Gentle tug (if they enjoy it)
- [ ] Hand targeting ("touch")
- [ ] Learning a trick together

ROUTINE & COMFORT

- [ ] Same meal and walk times
- [ ] A wind-down routine at bedtime
- [ ] Soft voice and slow movements
- [ ] Letting them choose to come for a fuss

MY DOG'S FAVOURITES

- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]
- [ ]

NOTES

UNDERSTANDING YOUR DOG

Trigger log

Note anything that worries or excites your dog. Patterns help you plan, and help a vet or behaviourist if you need one.

DATE	WHAT HAPPENED	DISTANCE	HOW MY DOG REACTED	WHAT HELPED

NOTES

UNDERSTANDING YOUR DOG

Other pets, children & visitors

Introductions should be slow and calm. Your rescue may have advice for your dog specifically.

Other dogs

Introduce on neutral ground, on walks side by side at a comfortable distance, before meeting at home.

Cats

Keep them separate at first. Swap bedding to share smells, then try short supervised sightings behind a gate.

Children

Teach children to let the dog come to them, never to disturb a sleeping or eating dog, and to give the safe space a wide berth. Always supervise.

Visitors

Hold off for the first week or two. Then ask visitors to ignore the dog and let them say hello in their own time.

Resources

Some dogs guard food, toys or beds. Feed separately and give space at meal times.

When to pause

If your dog seems stressed, go back a step. There's no rush.

NOTES

GETTING HELP

When to get help

Asking for help early is a good thing. You don't have to work it out alone.

SPEAK TO YOUR VET IF

- [ ] Your dog stops eating for more than a day or two
- [ ] You notice pain, limping, sickness or diarrhoea
- [ ] Behaviour changes suddenly
- [ ] Your dog seems anxious all the time
- [ ] You're worried about anything health-related

CONTACT YOUR RESCUE IF

- [ ] You need advice about your dog's history
- [ ] Things aren't working out
- [ ] You need support or reassurance
- [ ] You need help with introductions

A QUALIFIED BEHAVIOURIST OR TRAINER

For fear, reactivity, separation problems or aggression, ask your vet to refer you to a qualified behaviourist. In the UK, the Animal Behaviour and Training Council (ABTC) keeps a register of qualified practitioners. Look for kind, reward-based methods, and avoid anyone who uses punishment, shock or prong collars.

CONTACTS

My vet _____

Rescue contact _____

Trainer / behaviourist _____

NOTES

RECORDS

My dog's records

Copy details from your rescue paperwork.

ABOUT MY DOG

Name (and rescue name) _____

Breed / type _____

Approx. age _____

Adoption date _____

Rescue _____

HEALTH

Microchip number _____

Neutered _____

Vaccinations _____

Last flea & worm _____

Known conditions _____

HISTORY (IF KNOWN)

RESCUE NOTES & ADVICE

RECORDS

Vet, vaccinations & treatments

DATE	WHAT	VET / PRODUCT	NEXT DUE	NOTES

NOTES

FOR SITTERS & FAMILY

Dog care sheet

Especially important for rescue dogs: share their triggers and what helps.

DOG

Name _____

Age _____

Microchip _____

FOOD

Food & amount _____

Times _____

Treats _____

WALKS

Times & where _____

Lead / harness _____

Avoid _____

TRIGGERS

Things that worry them _____

Signs they need space _____

What helps _____

HEALTH

Medicines _____

Vet & phone _____

Insurance _____

CONTACTS

My mobile _____

Back-up _____

Rescue _____

NOTES

MEMORIES

Our story

Write down the moments that show how far you've come.

GOTCHA DAY

Date _____

FIRST TIME THEY SLEPT DEEPLY

Date _____

FIRST TAIL WAG

Date _____

FIRST TIME THEY CAME FOR A CUDDLE

Date _____

FAVOURITE WALK

Date _____

FUNNIEST HABIT

Date _____

PHOTO

THANK YOU

Thank you for adopting

Thank you for giving a rescue dog a home, and for choosing Larkspur & Co. If this guide helped, a short Etsy review means the world to a small Glasgow business.

A NOTE TO MY DOG